

customers at the bottom of the stakeholder chain. Public companies are the worst offenders, as shareholders come first, Wall Street second, and executives third. Guess who sits at the bottom? You and I.

My repeated, and often preached, motto to my employees was, “The customer pays your paycheck, not me—keep them happy.” You see, my stakeholder wasn’t my selfish desires for fast cars and big houses. It was my customer, because I knew *they had the power*. My loyalty was with my customer. Yes, I had a boss, and the boss had the keys to everything I selfishly wanted.

LOOK BIG, ACT SMALL

During Mr. Miller’s gym class in my sophomore year of high school, I became aware of Mark Cegraves—except there was no such student. Mr. Miller had a knack for butchering the simplest of names: Henderson became Hankerson, Seagroves became Cegraves, and Rickson became Rakesh. No matter what your name was, Mr. Miller would shred it. I don’t know if he was illiterate or just old.

So fast-forward more than a decade, and who is listed on my Web site as my chief technology officer? Mark Cegraves. Oh, and look who’s my web developer—Gretchen Hankerson! Wow, so did I hire my friends from high school? No, I didn’t, especially since their names were just mere illusions of the real people. None of these people worked for me. Yet if you visited my Web site’s “Contact” or “About Us” page, they were listed as employees in high profile positions: CTO, business development, or Web producer. These people weren’t employees, but it looked like my staff was big, and growing.

I admit that this started off as a harmless “inside joke” with my employees, but I eventually realized it had a benefit: it was branding my product to look big. Dominating. Well-funded. Growing. Of course, I’m not sure if butchered names from a 1987 gym class serving as employee apparitions was ethical, but my purpose and intention was clear: *I wanted to look big and act small*.

SETTING UP SUCS

Big companies notoriously give poor service as a model of expectation. Meanwhile, small companies are known to give better service with a personal touch. My objective was to look like I had the power of a big company, yet give personal service as if I were a one-person operation. When you receive personal, exemplary service from a big company, you create a sucs event and create loyal, evangelical customers.

Anywhere customer service is expected to suck, you have a business opportunity. Looking big and acting small is a setup for sucs events. The customer expects mediocre service from the start. This tactic works well for any company that operates without a physical presence. Obviously, you can’t look big if you own a small retail store, but for those of us with Internet companies, you can.